

Weekend Tech Byte: Ticketmaster's real moat isn't Live Nation - A look at the technology stack behind ticketing

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By Ian Moore

Everyone thinks something different when they hear "Ticketmaster." Happy fans think of their favorite artist. Angry fans think fees. Politicians think "re-elect me". Lawyers think payday. Operators think "that's a lot of work for \$1B of EBITDA".

When an arena's general manager signs with Ticketmaster, the venue is buying much more than a blue-tinted front-end platform to sell nosebleed seats. That website comes with a box-office operating system that can meter an onsale without breaking down, take card info without double-selling the entire 12th row, settle face value to the promoter, and accept an Apple Wallet at Door M halfway through the first quarter while everyone's Instagram Reels are clogging bandwidth and murdering LTE. Fans get a ticket, but venues get Host, Ignite, SafeTix, a fleet of scanners, and a refund desk that has to work when the artist cancels at 4:15 (doors were at 4). There are a myriad of reasons why this infrastructure is stickier than many investors appreciate.

Every fan wants a ticket to see their favorite artist, but artists can only tour so many days of the year at so many venues. Supply is structurally far below demand, which is a key reason I recommend owning LYV, TKO, and FWON (and likely also why they trade at premium valuations on GAAP EPS). If you focus on the supply-demand mismatch but ignore the infrastructure that gets the fan an authentic, trusted, irrevocable token that gets them in the door smoothly on opening night, then every new ticketing marketplace looks like consumer relief. In reality, inventory + identity + payment + scanner must all work in concert (ha) to fill big empty buildings with people who are eager to buy food, drinks, parking and wifi.

This blast is meant to be a comprehensive walkthrough of the ticketing stack, from issuance to queue physics to rotating credentials, yield, and gate. What would mandates change with respect to what venues actually care about? Not much.

WHAT IS A TICKET?

When a fan buys a ticket, tech investors should think of three product streams and three main ways they are packaged/stacked.

Host. Ticketmaster's core ticketing engine for live events. It manages concert inventory in real time, including seat maps, presales, public onsales, ticket reservations, and transaction processing. Most importantly, it is designed to handle extremely high traffic during major onsales while ensuring that the same seat cannot be sold twice. When industry participants refer to Ticketmaster's "concert ticketing back end," they are typically referring to Host.

Archtics. Ticketmaster's account and inventory management platform for sports teams, performing arts organizations, and other season-ticket businesses. Unlike Host, which is optimized for single-event transactions, Archtics is designed to manage long-term customer relationships, season-ticket accounts, renewals, premium seating, partial plans, and other recurring inventory. Because it sits at the center of a team's customer database and annual ticketing operations, it is deeply embedded in business workflows and can be difficult to replace.

Ignite (& formerly Presence). Ticketmaster's digital ticketing and venue access platforms. They connect ticket inventory from both Host and Archtics to the fan's mobile credential, enabling ticket delivery, authentication, transfers, resale, mobile wallet integration, and venue entry. In practical terms, Ignite is the technology layer (developer-facing ticket management and authentication SDKs) that turns a ticket purchase into a secure digital pass that can be scanned and accepted at the venue.

The first package is **Primary**. The Primary onsale is the point where the rights holder (artist/team/venue/promoter) allocates inventory into the ecosystem. For Ticketmaster's venues, that has historically been handled by Host or Archtics. These systems were historically surfaced to fan apps and partners through Presence and are now surfaced for new development through Ignite. The face value of these sales flows, generally, to the rightsholder. Ticketmaster is primarily an agency business, selling on behalf of clients and keeping a portion of the service charge.

Second is **Direct**. There are a multitude of hybrid offerings in this vertical. Often these still flow through Host and Ignite. There are four main patterns: (1) a true alternative stack (e.g., AXS, Dice, Eventbrite, Fever, Paciolan, or DIY); (2) a white-label offering on Ticketmaster's primary OS (e.g., brand.com or team apps, which are still supported by Host and Archtics under the hood); (3) an open-distribution partner, comprising retail apps that list the event, create a Host order via partner API, and return a rotating entry token rendered through Ignite Secure Entry; and (4) a rails-agnostic storefront that never touches inventory or the gate.

Third is **Secondary**. This, obviously, is when tickets are re-listed (not reissued), matching buyers and sellers and charging fees on one or both sides. Ticketmaster offers Official or Verified Resale, which run on the same rails as its Primary package (same lifecycle, new entry credential that gets bound to a new account/device). Other platforms (StubHub, SeatGeek, Vivid etc.) host Open Secondary listings. An integrity challenge unique to Open Secondary is that listings can be speculative, meaning a ticket can be listed before the seller has possession of the token.

EXHIBIT 1: The three major ticketing packages

	PRIMARY	DIRECT	SECONDARY
Who issues	Rights holder via designated primary (TW Host / Ignite, AXS, Paciolan...)	Artist / venue / team on own site or white-label	Nobody new — already-issued ticket re-lists
Gate mint	Primary entry stack (SafeTix / equivalent)	Often SAME back-end OR true alternate stack	Re-bind / re-issue on transfer; PDF = gray risk
MoR	Typically ticketer as AGENT: face → rights holder	Self / white-label / or primary still MoR — ASK	Marketplace often MoR or facilitator; seller = fan/broker
Fees	Service + facility + order processing waterfall	SaaS / platform fee + payment; or primary waterfall	Buyer + seller take rates (platform-specific)
Price	Face + optional Platinum / dynamic	Face set by rights holder; may still use primary yield	Market clearing; speculative listings exist

Source: Bernstein analysis

From the venue's perspective, there are up to five parts in a ticket's lifecycle: discovery, presale, onsale, transfer, and entry. Each requires a smooth UX and a functional back-end.

EXHIBIT 2: The lifecycle of a ticket



Source: Bernstein analysis

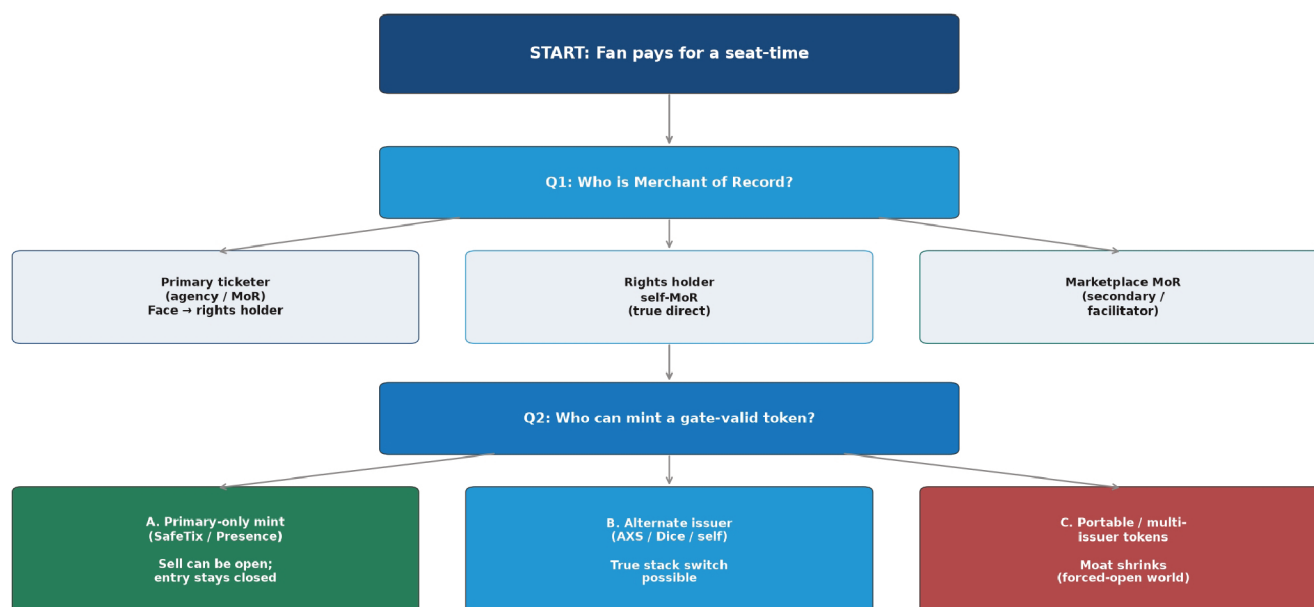
Who truly issues the ticket?

MoR status and the Mint are often conflated but represent two distinct economic functions within the live events ecosystem. The former appears on the consumer's card statement and therefore bears responsibility for payment processing, taxes, refunds, chargebacks, cancellations, and other consumer-facing liabilities. The latter is who has the ability to issue a venue-valid ticket that will grant entry to an event. That function represents the core access-control layer of the ticketing value chain and, in our view, the more durable competitive moat.

Importantly, MoR arrangements are not uniform across markets. Depending on contractual structure, jurisdiction, and local regulatory requirements, a ticketing platform may operate either as an agent facilitating the transaction or as the true MoR. As a result, investors should avoid assuming a single legal or commercial model applies globally.

When evaluating competitive positioning, two separate questions are critical. First, which entity appears on the consumer's card statement and ultimately bears economic responsibility for the transaction? Second, and more importantly from a strategic perspective, which entity has the right and technical capability to issue a ticket that will be recognized for venue entry? The former determines transaction economics and liability allocation, while the latter often determines control of the customer relationship and the durability of the platform's market position.

EXHIBIT 3: Who issues the ticket? The MoR or the Mint? Both... but the Mint has the most impact on venue economics & the fan experience



Source: Bernstein analysis

How it works in practice... based on Ticketmaster's developer docs

Ticketmaster's developer documentation describes a controlled fulfillment workflow in which "open selling" functions as a distribution layer only until ticket mint authority transfers. Within this process, partners first identify inventory with the safeTixEnabled flag at the availability stage, then create a host order that includes a third_party_account_id. Order Management subsequently returns an encrypted Rotating Entry Token, which is rendered through the Secure Entry SDK. The Secure Render API refreshes the token both whenever the ticket is viewed and no later than twenty hours before the event.

Ticketmaster's cited partner service-level agreements indicate approximately 800 milliseconds latency at 99.5% availability for Order Management and approximately 500 milliseconds latency at 99.99% availability for Token Refresh. Under this model, partners are permitted to sell tickets, but rendering a SafeTix ticket continues to require Ticketmaster's encrypted token infrastructure and Ticketmaster's SDK. An open-gate protocol in which independent parties can fully control ticket issuance and presentation would remove these crucial safety features, which have gone through countless iterations, night after night at arenas and stadiums across the globe.

SIX PRODUCTS, ONE LOGO

Ticketmaster is often viewed through the lens of the fan checkout experience, leading many technology investors to frame the consumer as the primary customer. In practice, however, Ticketmaster's contractual customers are venues, sports teams, promoters, and building operators responsible for managing attendance, inventory, payments, and event-day operations at scale. As a result, the product being purchased is best understood as venue infrastructure rather than a standalone eCommerce solution, and Ticketmaster is best understood as an integrated platform comprising five interdependent layers: **client, edge + queue, APP / API, inventory + pricing, payments, and**

venue entry.

The most visible layer is Ticketmaster's two-sided marketplace. Fans use the platform to discover events, receive recommendations, and engage with targeted marketing, while venues and promoters leverage demand-generation tools designed to drive ticket sales. Functionally, this marketplace resembles platforms such as Amazon or Booking.com, where value is created through efficient matching of demand and supply at scale. Because this consumer-facing component is the most visible part of the ecosystem, investors often overemphasize its importance relative to the broader technology stack operating behind the scenes.

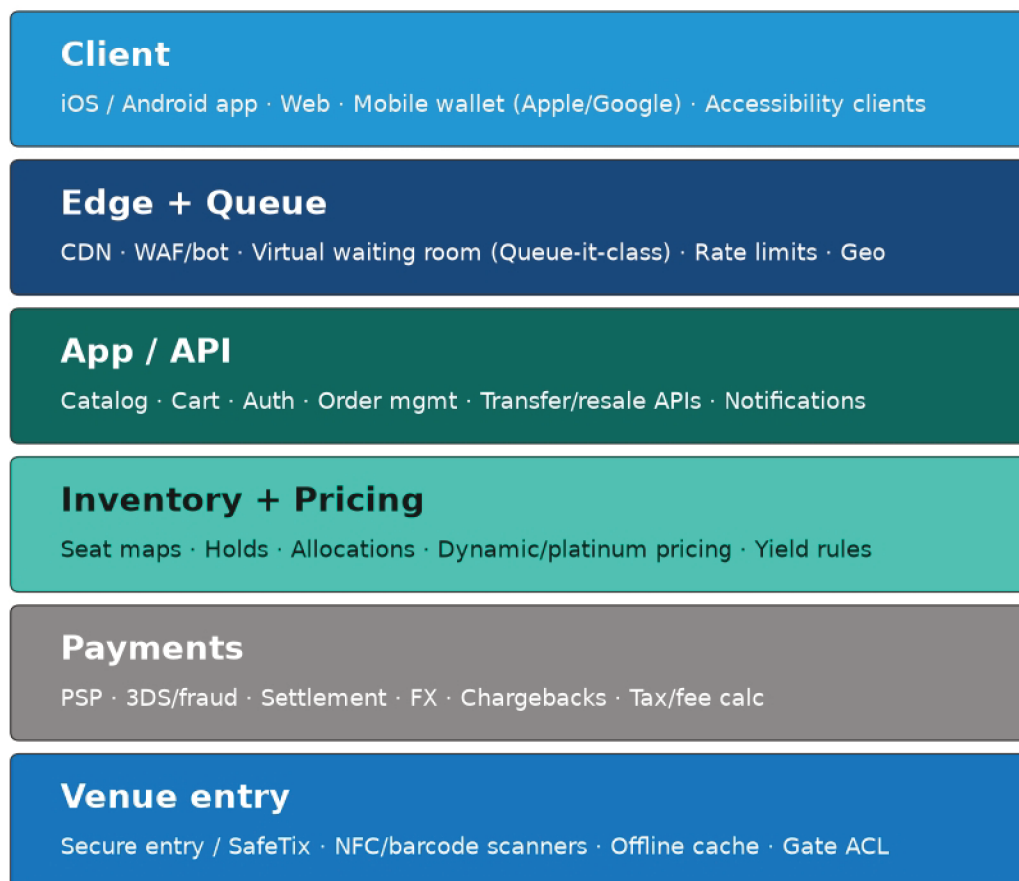
Beneath the marketplace sits Ticketmaster's (1) venue software and (2) box-office platform, which serves as the operational backbone of live entertainment. The system manages ticket inventory, customer relationships, point-of-sale activity, and ticket allocation workflows. Prior to a public onsale, inventory is typically segmented across numerous hold categories, including artist and production holds, VIP packages, fan club allotments, Verified Fan inventory, sponsor and credit-card partner exclusives, media allocations, house seats, season-ticket commitments, and suite inventory. Managing the release and reallocation of these holds is a complex operational process. Consequently, events that appear sold out despite visible empty seats may reflect uncleared inventory holds rather than insufficient consumer demand. In practical terms, this layer functions as a venue-specific combination of Shopify and Toast.

The next layer is payments infrastructure. Ticketmaster facilitates payment authorization, capture, fee collection, settlement, and reconciliation across millions of transactions. While consumers tend to focus on fees displayed during checkout, the economics of the business are more appropriately evaluated through payment volume, fee-bearing gross transaction value, and take rates. Similar to payment platforms such as Stripe or Adyen, Ticketmaster operates the financial rails connecting buyers, venues, promoters, and other stakeholders. Importantly, face-value ticket proceeds generally flow to rights holders and venues and do not constitute Ticketmaster revenue.

Finally, Ticketmaster provides the admission and venue-access infrastructure required for event-day execution. Mobile ticketing, barcodes, NFC credentials, handheld scanners, offline-entry functionality, digital wallet integrations, and box-office support all sit within this layer. The challenge is not simply validating tickets, but doing so reliably when tens of thousands of attendees may arrive simultaneously and cellular networks are under significant strain. Conceptually, this functionality resembles an airline boarding-pass system combined with airport gate readers, adapted for arena and stadium environments and required to perform seamlessly under peak-load conditions.

Identity and fraud-prevention capabilities permeate the entire ecosystem. Modern ticketing environments require systems capable of distinguishing legitimate consumers from bots, proxy networks, and professional scalpers, often within milliseconds during highly scrutinized, high-demand onsales. Ticketmaster's technology stack includes account management, Verified Fan tools, device intelligence, authentication systems, and risk-scoring capabilities designed to preserve access for genuine consumers. This layer effectively combines elements of identity management, fraud detection, and cybersecurity into a unified operational workflow.

The company's core value proposition to venues lies in combining these functions within a single operating system capable of managing the full event lifecycle, from demand generation and inventory allocation through payment settlement and physical ingress on event day.

EXHIBIT 4: **The six products behind Ticketmaster's stack**

Source: Bernstein analysis

As we mentioned earlier, a significant architectural shift has occurred recently in the fan-facing orchestration layer (the inventory systems, Host & Archtics, are intact). Through 2023, Ticketmaster's mobile ecosystem was centered on the Presence SDK (PSDK), which handled authentication, retrieval of Host and Archtics orders, ticket rendering, transfers, resale functionality, wallet integration, and scanner connectivity. According to Ticketmaster developer-portal guidance as of September 2026, the company will not release additional versions of PSDK, although documentation remains available for existing implementations. New development has migrated to Ignite, which is now the primary mobile platform.

Ignite consists of three SDKs: Retail, which supports discovery through purchase; Tickets, which supports ticket management, transfers, resale, modules, and event entry; and Accounts, which provides a unified login layer across Ticketmaster back-end systems. Within the Tickets SDK, Authentication and Secure Entry functionality are embedded. Secure Entry serves as the active client layer for SafeTix rotating barcodes, QR-based credentials, and wallet-based entry experiences. Notably, Ignite Authentication continues to interface with both Host and Archtics account systems, enabling a team or venue application to present inventory from both platforms within a single wallet

experience. Legacy PSDK integrations remain capable of rendering tickets, but feature development has consolidated around Ignite rather than the older framework.

The Ignite brand also encompasses a separate but related product offering, Ignite Venue Apps. These should not be conflated with the Ignite SDK platform. Ignite Venue Apps are white-label venue applications that combine ticket purchase, event entry, wayfinding, seat upgrades, and concessions into a single consumer interface. While the SDK platform and Venue Apps serve different functions, both ultimately sit atop the same Host and Archtics inventory systems and leverage Secure Entry credentials.

Taken together, this architecture helps explain why customer migration away from Ticketmaster is in neither the venue nor the fan's best interest. Replacing a ticketing provider is a cumbersome process requiring precise execution involving inventory-history migration, settlement-file conversion, venue access hardware, and updates to the SDK infrastructure embedded in venue and team applications. The challenge extends well beyond a simple change of distribution endpoint. A competing vendor may be able to sell tickets, but if it cannot initialize Ignite Secure Entry within the venue's existing access-control environment, it is effectively attempting to present unsupported credentials to infrastructure built around NFC- and rotating-barcode-based entry systems.

EXHIBIT 5: An alternate view of the lifecycle of a ticket



Source: Bernstein analysis

THE ONSALE PROCESS

Waiting-room functionality is increasingly commoditized. Instead, we believe Ticketmaster's competitive advantages stem from the integration of admission control with inventory management, Verified Fan, Request, payments infrastructure, SafeTix/Secure Entry, and years of operational experience managing concert-scale demand events.

Evidently, organizational or structural separation of concert promotion and ticketing would not simply create two waiting rooms. It could create a system in which responsibility for admission rates, inventory management, and payment-capacity constraints becomes fragmented across multiple actors. The resulting risk is a degradation of end-to-end backpressure management, manifesting as more errors, more users flagged for potentially suspicious refresh behavior, and longer wait times during peak onsales... none of which benefits the fan.

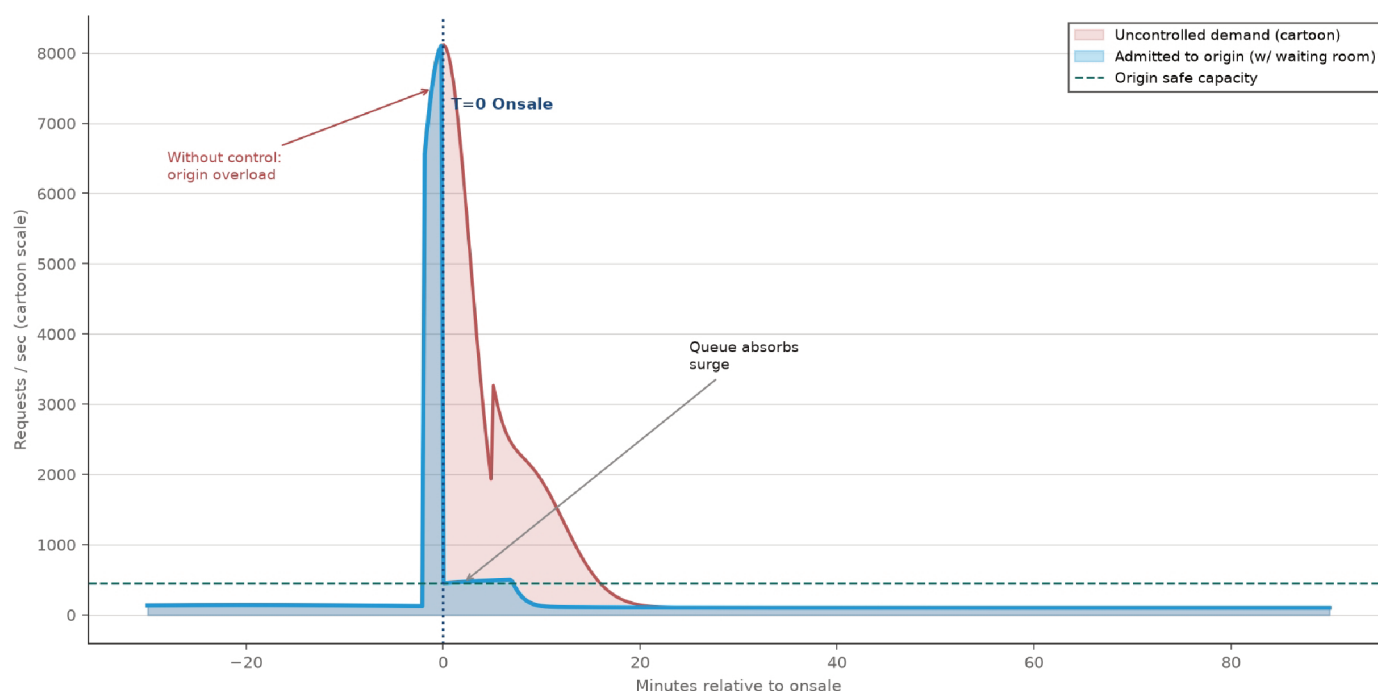
Mechanics

The traffic profile associated with high-demand onsales resembles a distributed denial-of-service (DDoS) event, although the majority of requests represent legitimate purchase intent. Millions of consumers, alongside industrial-scale bot activity, can arrive within seconds to compete for tens of thousands of distinct seat-time inventory units. Each successful transaction requires access to scarce inventory through a write lock, followed by payment authorization. As a result, the origin system cannot simultaneously admit the full volume of demand without exhausting inventory-hold capacity and overwhelming the checkout process.

To manage this imbalance, the platform introduces a virtual waiting room that functions as a buffering and admission-control layer. Shoppers are released into the transaction flow at a metered rate, inventory is held using time-to-live (TTL) reservations, and admission is calibrated to the throughput that the hold-and-payment pipeline can reliably process. In these environments, arrival rates can spike by orders of magnitude above sustainable service rates. Absent a queuing mechanism, the system must either shed demand or over-admit users, increasing the risk of inventory contention, transaction failures, and checkout instability. **The queue is the primary control surface for the underlying supply-and-demand dynamics (i.e. a feature, not a bug).**

Many product innovations across the ticketing stack appear to address the same underlying constraint: a uniquely scarce seat-time inventory unit. Features such as SafeTix, Platinum, Verified Fan, official resale, scanner fleets, wallet passes, and Ignite entry rendering should be viewed as successive refinements designed to manage, authenticate, distribute, transfer, or validate access to that finite inventory throughout its lifecycle.

EXHIBIT 6: **Queue Physics 101: How waiting rooms convert crowd spikes into controlled drain**



Source: Bernstein analysis

The central question in ticketing infrastructure is whether scarce downstream capacity can be protected during these extreme demand events. Ticketmaster's November 2022 Eras Tour post-mortem illustrates the magnitude of the challenge: approximately 3.5B system requests, roughly 4x the company's prior peak; more than 3.5M Verified Fan registrations; roughly 1.5M access codes distributed; and approximately 2M tickets sold through Ticketmaster in a single day. Despite that scale, roughly 15% of site interactions experienced issues. Given the scale of these events, the proposition that peak-load problems can be solved simply by adding more nodes (or pods of Kubernetes) materially understates the bottlenecks in the system. At the end of the day, **all that matters is maximizing sell-through and that is achieved by admitting users from the queue via a placement methodology that they perceive as legitimate.**

Maximizing conversion

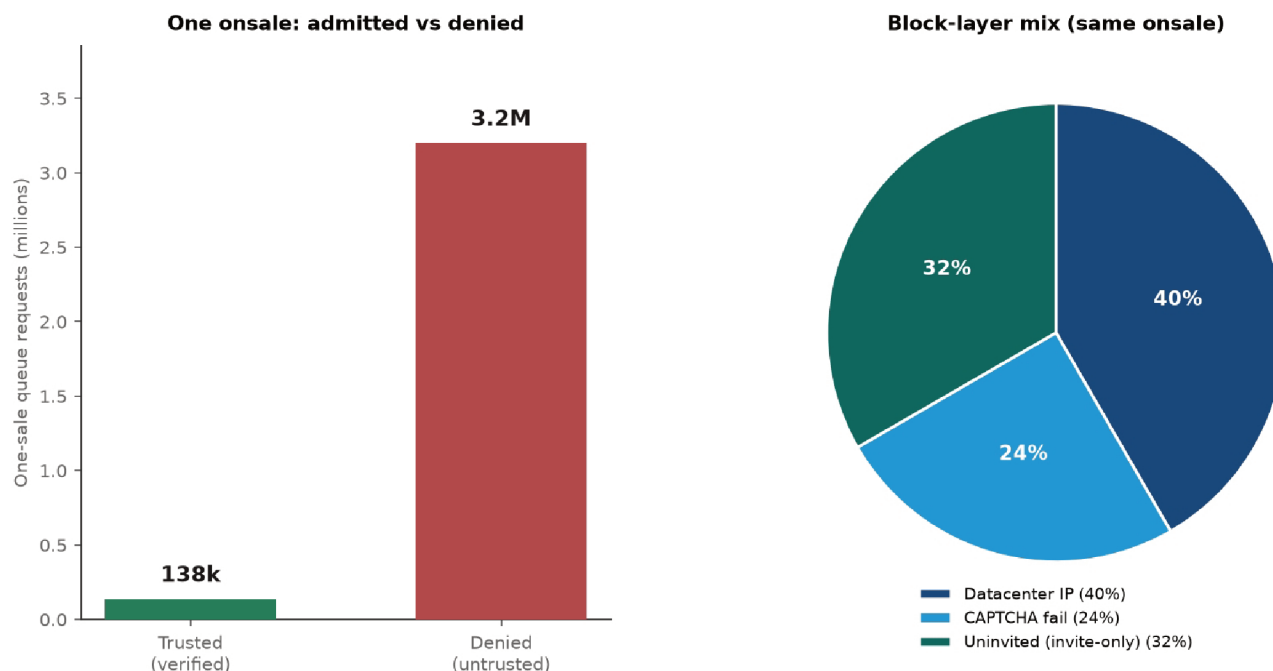
According to Ticketmaster's December 2025 description of Smart Queue, fans sign in and enter a waiting room before the sale begins. At sale start, users are assigned a position and admitted at a rate determined by Ticketmaster with the objective of reducing checkout errors and increasing sell-through. Only after admission do users access the interactive seat map and checkout flow. Ticketmaster also describes adjacent capabilities including in-queue messaging, bot filtering, Artist Presale eligibility management, and live demand signals that inform inventory strategy.

Waiting rooms typically open 15-30 minutes before an onsale. Fans who join after the queue is established move behind those already present. Refresh behavior is treated as a potential bot signal. Ticketmaster indicates that only a few hundred customers may be shopping simultaneously during large events, with even fewer active shoppers for smaller venues. Once admitted, a user's turn is generally reserved for approximately ten minutes, although admission does not guarantee ticket availability. The key observation is that Smart Queue functions as an admission-control mechanism. The value to venues and fans lies in dynamically matching the admission rate to the throughput of the hold-and-pay pipeline.

The legitimacy problem

Queue placement has become a point of public scrutiny. In May 2026 press reports, Ticketmaster Global President Saumil Mehta disputed claims that queue positions are assigned randomly, stating that security measures operate in real time and that "bots do not get first dibs." Our interpretation is that queue placement is likely security-weighted. Such an approach is logically consistent with anti-bot objectives, as it potentially rewards accounts with stronger signals of authenticity; however, it also introduces transparency and false-positive risks. If legitimate users systematically receive less favorable outcomes because of risk-scoring decisions, trust in the process may erode. In that sense, queue legitimacy is not merely a communications issue but a product requirement, and failures tend to become highly visible, which can either reinforce or challenge the stickiness of any platform with venues who want to see their shows sell out.

EXHIBIT 7: Queue Physics 102: Addressing the legitimacy problem



Source: Queue-it case study "Behind-the-scenes of an onsale", Bernstein analysis

Verified Fan

Verified Fan and the waiting room serve distinct functions. Verified Fan is an upstream eligibility and allocation mechanism designed to reduce the pool of participants before the sale begins. Fans register, Ticketmaster evaluates signals associated with bot activity and reseller-like behavior, and qualified users receive unique access codes while others may be waitlisted once demand exceeds supply. Possessing a code permits access to the sale but does not eliminate the queue, nor does it guarantee a ticket. Code holders still compete for inventory once admitted.

In the Eras Tour post-mortem, Ticketmaster stated that all 2M Verified Fan onsale tickets were sold to verified buyers and that fewer than 5% of tour tickets appeared on the secondary market versus a typically cited 20-30% without Verified Fan. Related products demonstrate the same design philosophy. Artist Sign-Up provides branded registration experiences while generating demand-quality data. Ticketmaster Request, introduced in December 2025, allows fans to register interest and pre-authorize payment, with allocations made according to defined objectives while filtering bad actors. These systems move ticket allocation away from pure first-come-first-served mechanics and toward eligibility- and identity-based allocation. In economic terms, a lottery among verified identities converts a speed contest into an allocation process. For the latest iteration of monetizable products that also aim to improve legitimacy, look no further than Live Nation's Reserved by Spotify partnership.

Layered defenses against bots

Botting remains an economically rational activity whenever expected resale profits exceed acquisition costs. Secondary-market spreads on high-demand events can justify expenditures on residential proxy networks, account farms, automated checkout tooling, CAPTCHA-solving services, and diversified payment methods. Expected value is a function of win probability multiplied by resale markup, less acquisition costs. As long as that expected value remains positive at scale, the arms race persists.

Accordingly, anti-bot defenses should be viewed as mechanisms that increase attacker cost rather than as permanent solutions. Identity verification and lottery-based access reduce who can participate. CAPTCHAs largely introduce friction and delay. Ticketmaster's March 2026 identity-security materials describe AI-driven risk modeling before onsales, passkeys, SafeTix account-linked barcodes, and proactive challenges for suspicious accounts. Queue controls, identity systems, transfer restrictions, and SafeTix-based fulfillment therefore appear to us to be complementary.

Inventory is the bottleneck

Once a fan is admitted, the fundamental challenge shifts from traffic management to maintaining correctness over scarce, mutable inventory state. Industry system-design consensus suggests a workflow consisting of admission-token validation, seat selection, temporary inventory holds governed by expiration timers, payment authorization, final order commitment, and inventory release following cancellation or timeout. The design tradeoffs are significant. Holds that persist too long sequester inventory and reduce utilization. Holds that expire too quickly increase cart abandonment and customer frustration. Coarse locking strategies can cripple concurrency, while highly granular locking can create hot-key contention. Idempotent checkout flows are essential because they distinguish a safe retry from a double-sold seat. Smart Queue's stated goal of admitting users at a "rate that minimizes checkout errors" is therefore effectively an admission cap calibrated to the capacity of the hold-and-payment pipeline. The waiting room protects admission control while the inventory service protects transactional correctness. Payment networks on the other hand introduce external capacity constraints that cannot simply be autoscaled on demand. As a result, peak-event engineering is really primarily a backpressure problem.

ROTATING CREDENTIAL MECHANICS - THE CRUX OF REMEDY IMPLICATIONS

As we have written in an earlier section, the critical issue for venue customers (and therefore for investors) is who retains the authority to mint a gate-valid entry credential and whether any open-distribution remedy would alter that authority. Ticketmaster's Secure Entry architecture appears designed to preserve control over credential issuance even as ticket distribution pathways evolve.

Historically, **ticket authentication has evolved in response to the vulnerabilities of prior formats**. Paper tickets with physical stubs were susceptible to photocopying and loss in transit but did not require a mobile device. The subsequent shift to print-at-home PDFs and

static QR codes improved convenience but created a new problem: possession of a copied barcode often conferred the same admission rights as possession of the original ticket. In practice, screenshots, forwarded PDFs, or duplicated printouts could function as valid entry credentials because the barcode itself acted as a bearer instrument.

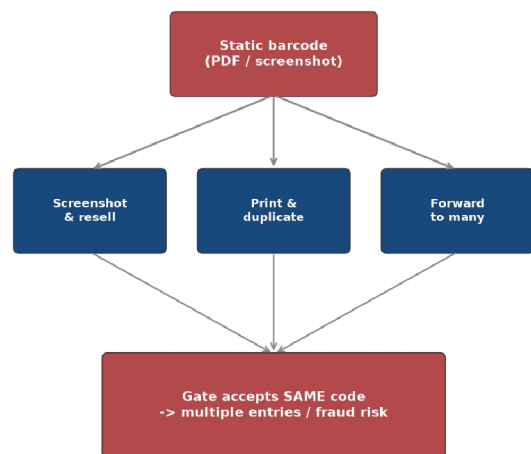
SafeTix represents Ticketmaster's response to this challenge. Instead of relying on a static credential, SafeTix delivers a rotating entry token rendered within the authorized application environment. According to Ticketmaster's fan-facing materials, the barcode refreshes approximately every 15 seconds, rendering screenshots and printouts ineffective because captured images quickly become stale. Ticketmaster also states that tickets are tied to a verified account, saved to the authorized device once viewed in the application, and can be added to Apple Wallet or Google Wallet for venues where network connectivity may be constrained. Ticket credentials are also device-bound such that transferable screen recordings are blocked.

The platform architecture reinforces this control. Under Ticketmaster's July 2026 PRIMARY Tickets SDK overview, the current development stack consists of three major components: the Tickets SDK (including listings, ticket details, transfer, resale, and related modules), the Authentication SDK (sign-in across Ticketmaster back-end systems), and the Secure Entry SDK (SafeTix rotating barcodes, QR presentation, and Wallet support). The Secure Entry implementation is now delivered through Ignite's Secure Entry SDK rather than the legacy Presence SDK. While the Presence SDK remains available in a frozen state for applications that have not yet migrated, new partner integrations and team-application development are directed toward Ignite.

Wallet-based delivery represents the latest stage in this authentication evolution. Apple Wallet and Google Wallet credentials, combined with NFC presentation where supported, provide an offline-capable admission path that is generally more resilient during periods of network congestion. This is particularly relevant for large venues where cellular capacity may be impaired immediately prior to an event. **Compared with static PDFs or screenshots, Wallet-based credentials are more difficult to duplicate or forward and may represent the most reliable ingress mechanism when venue connectivity deteriorates.**

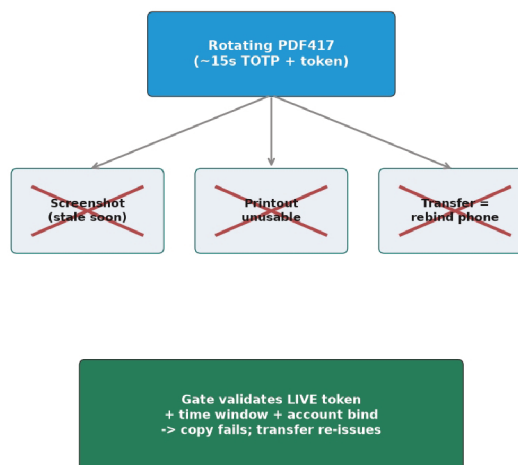
EXHIBIT 8: Trust is crucial to the live events ecosystem, and Ticketmaster's multi-layered and ever-evolving credentialing framework promotes it between fans & venues

Static barcode (legacy PDF / screenshot)



Threat model: copy = valid forever

Rotating SafeTix / Secure Entry



Threat model: possession of live device required

Source: Bernstein analysis

Key SafeTix implementation details include rotating PDF417 barcodes with QR fallback, NFC-based credentials, a device-specific GUID used as a fraud signal, and offline-fallback mechanisms. Documentation also highlights a resilience mechanism: if a gate-time token refresh fails, the SDK can fall back to a credential refreshed roughly 20 hours earlier that remains valid. This suggests event-day reliability depends

on both real-time connectivity and pre-distributed credentials. As a result, wallet-add rates prior to events may be among the most important operational metrics, with higher adoption supporting smoother ingress. Reported deployments include roughly 150 UltraQ pedestals and throughput exceeding 600 scans per minute. These scanner networks, software integrations, and operating procedures create meaningful switching costs. While competing marketplaces may facilitate ticket resale, they lack the ability to activate Ignite Secure Entry across the installed scanner ecosystem, limiting their ability to provide supported entry credentials.

There are broadly three choices available to venues:

Status Quo. Partners sell tickets, but Ticketmaster continues to mint the rotating entry credential and requires Ignite Secure Entry (or legacy PSDK infrastructure) to render it. Control of the entry credential remains with Ticketmaster. Under this structure, ticket sales may be broadly distributed, but venue entry remains closed because Ticketmaster retains authority over the credential accepted at the gate.

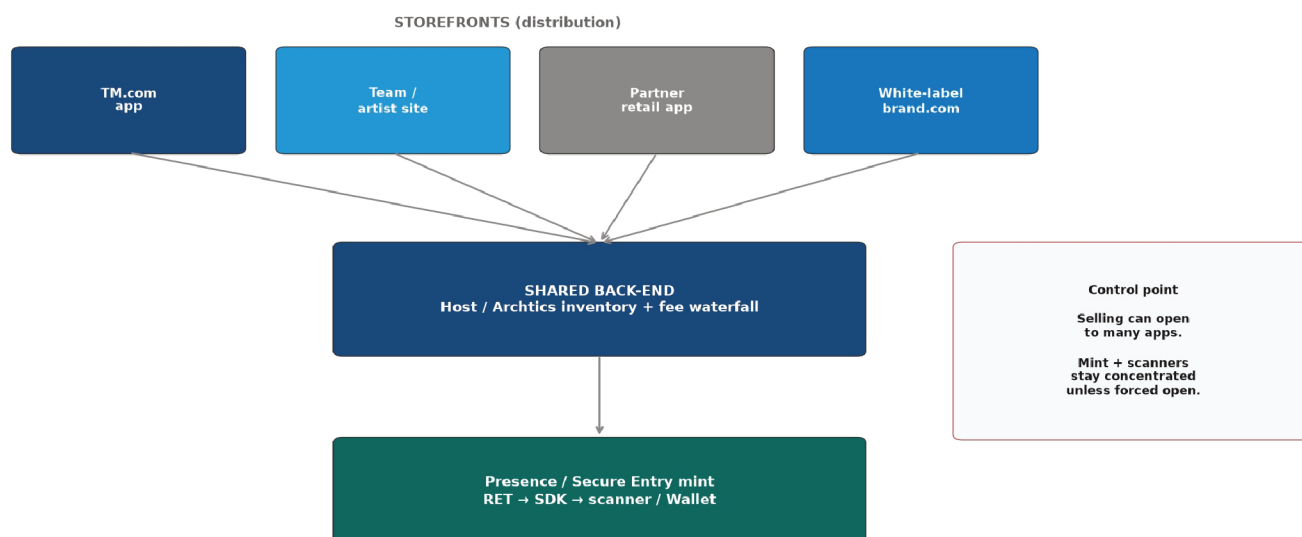
Open Distribution. Additional marketplaces gain the ability to sell Ticketmaster-backed inventory, with demand distributed across a larger set of storefronts; however, ticket minting remains centered on Ticketmaster. Economics may shift through changes in fee allocation, but the underlying validation infrastructure does not.

Portable or Multi-Issuer Entry. Third parties gain the ability to mint credentials that must be accepted by the same venue infrastructure. Under this model, the entry moat becomes materially weaker because scanners effectively become multi-tenant validators. Interoperability would be required across scanner firmware, wallet issuers, offline-cache protocols, and exception-handling procedures during peak ingress. As a result, venue operations would likely become more complex. Multi-tenant gate operations at doors-open may add operational layers and reconciliation requirements rather than improve throughput.

Implications of the proposed settlement with the DOJ

Under the proposal, Ticketmaster would be required to build and maintain an open distribution and ticket-authentication system that enables eligible third-party marketplaces to sell primary inventory for major concert venues operating on the Ticketmaster back end, without discriminatory treatment. Ticketmaster would also offer its back-end platform as a standalone product while remaining responsible for core back-end functions. Ticket transfers would be required to operate regardless of the originating primary marketplace, and Ticketmaster's transfer fee would be limited to a monitor-verified back-end service cost. Effectively, these measures would allow more venues to choose whichever option above would maximize their economics by streamlining the fan experience. We would argue that the status quo would remain optimal for most venue types.

EXHIBIT 9: An open distribution framework



Source: Bernstein analysis

PRICING & YIELD

Live-event yield management is governed by the same perishability economics as airline revenue management: once doors open, an unsold seat has no residual value; however, live entertainment operates under tighter brand, artist, and disclosure constraints than traditional travel & leisure markets. The combination of a one-time event, artist reputation considerations, and potential consumer backlash to visible price changes limits the use of a purely algorithmic surge-pricing model. As a result, the product is best understood as a constrained optimization problem coupled with a disclosure and customer-communication interface.

Terminology is important. A **classic fixed-face ticket** refers to a posted price level that remains unchanged until adjusted manually or through a pre-scheduled change. The artist or event organizer sets the initial price, although a ticketing desk may provide recommendations.

Official Platinum is a form of market-based pricing in the primary ticket market. According to Ticketmaster's help-center descriptions, Official Platinum tickets are not resale inventory; rather, they use a pricing approach analogous to airline and hotel yield management and operate within organizer-approved parameters. In the United Kingdom and Australia, **In Demand** is used as the name for the same broader product family.

Pricemaster refers to bulk repricing tools that allow groups of seats to be repriced during the sales cycle, enabling face-value adjustments after tickets have gone on sale.

By contrast, **Official Secondary** and **Verified Resale** involve tickets that have already been issued and are subsequently relisted for sale. Pricing in these channels is determined by the seller and the market-clearing process. These products represent secondary-market transactions rather than primary ticket issuance.

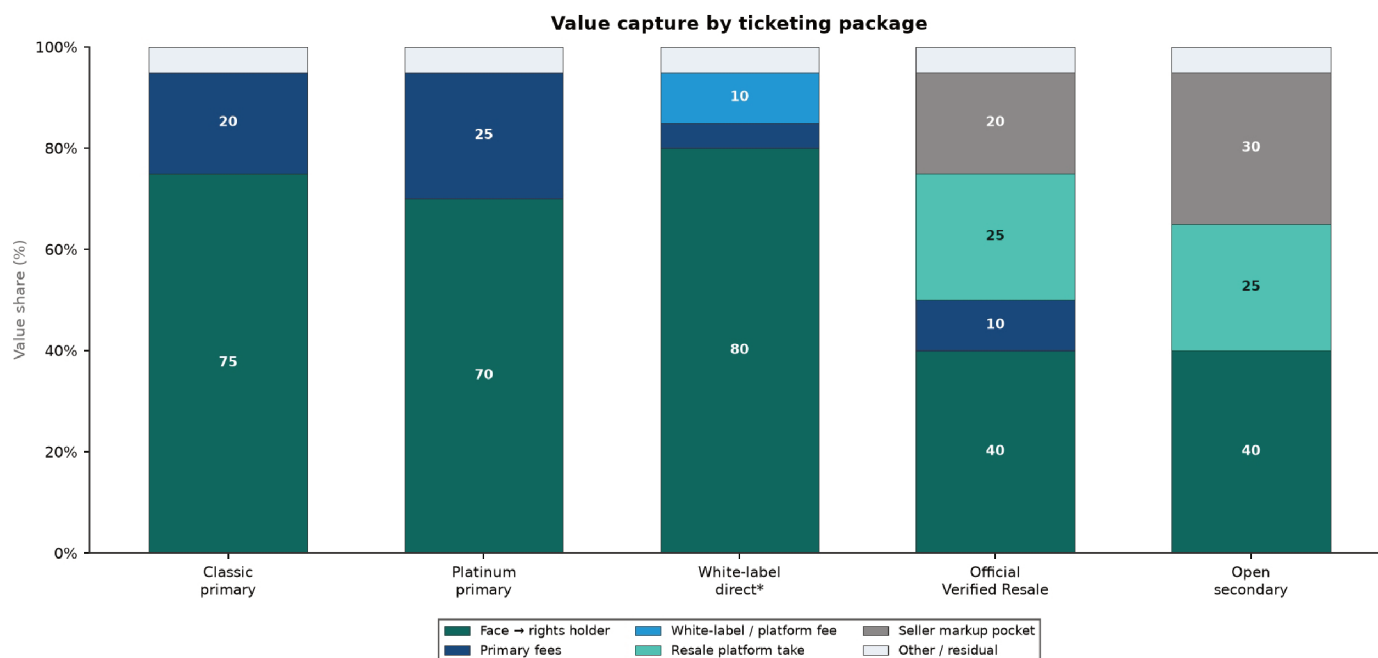
In general, secondary-market asking prices can serve as market comparables but can also create a unique feedback loop: resale prices can either validate primary-market pricing decisions or reinforce perceptions that primary sellers have extracted excessive value. As a result, **we believe that a revenue-management framework that optimizes solely for price and conversion may be sub-optimal over the long-term.** In live entertainment, brand protection, consumer fairness perceptions, regulatory constraints, and reputational risk operate as

binding constraints which must always be managed alongside supply-driven growth. Ticketmaster's intelligent pricing models honed over multiple touring cycles do just that.

Is intelligent pricing a durable technological moat?

Our working view is yes. While proprietary pricing algorithms certainly help, the commercial effort required to migrate more inventory toward sustainable yield frameworks, access to trusted primary-entry and transfer infrastructure, and contractual fee arrangements that make enhanced pricing tools economically attractive to rightsholders are beneficial to the entire ecosystem (fans, venues & artists) and are why we view Ticketmaster's moat as durable. Ultimately, distribution rights determine where (and whether) that technology is deployed, not vice-versa.

EXHIBIT 10: Who captures value in ticketing?



Source: Bernstein estimates

The economics of ticketing are distributed across multiple revenue pools, each defined by a distinct control point:

Face-Value Ticket Sales. Economics accrue primarily to the rights holder under an agency model. The key control point is inventory-allocation authority, which determines how and where ticket inventory is distributed.

Primary Service, Facility, and Order-Processing Fees. These fees are contractually shared between the ticketing platform and the venue. The critical control point is ownership of the checkout experience and fee-waterfall configuration.

Platinum and Dynamic Pricing Upside. This value pool largely benefits the rights holder, while fee revenue also increases through a higher average selling price (ASP). Key control points include pricing tools and artist participation or opt-in mechanisms.

Official Resale Economics. The primary platform generally captures the economics associated with official resale transactions. Control is exercised through ticket transfer functionality, ticket re-minting capabilities, and the resale listing interface. These capabilities are now surfaced through **Ignite Tickets** as well as Ticketmaster.com.

Open Secondary Market Economics. This pool is captured by marketplaces such as StubHub, SeatGeek, and other secondary exchanges. The principal control points are liquidity, marketplace trust, and merchant-of-record status.

Beyond these five revenue pools, additional layers of economic value reside in payments, foreign exchange, tax processing, identity management, and CRM ownership.

WHY VENUES REALLY STAY

Consider SoFi Stadium. The venue hosts ~150 ticketing gates supporting events with >66,000 attendees and throughput of >600 scans per minute. Seasonal staff rotate in and out, so "tap versus scan" is the MO. Once the finance team has built a settlement framework around this convention, replacing a ticketing provider becomes materially more complex than redirecting online traffic to a new checkout experience.

A venue that changes providers may need to recertify hardware, rewrite entry procedures, retrain large seasonal workforces, migrate venue or team applications away from Ignite (and potentially legacy PSDK deployments), and assume first-event execution risk. Through decades of iteration, Ticketmaster delivers lower fraud and chargeback activity, efficient entry, resale policies aligned with rightsholder requirements, and consistent settlement. When any of these nodes fails, the venue, the fan and the artist/rightsholder all suffer the consequences.

Long online queues, Platinum pricing screenshots, and visible fee disclosures create fan dissatisfaction and political scrutiny from time to time; however, those issues are not inherently addressed by introducing multiple ticketing providers into the same venue environment. The operational complexity of running parallel ticketing systems may create additional friction rather than improving the fan experience. For that reason, we believe Ticketmaster's competitive durability is best understood as a function of operational integration and venue workflow optimization, not influence over rightsholders and artists.

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BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

Ticker	Rating	Cur	17 Sep 2026		TTM Rel. Perf.	Cur	Reported EPS			Reported P/E (x)		
			Closing Price	Price Target			2025A	2026E	2027E	2025A	2026E	2027E
LYV (Live Nation)	O	USD	168.34	215.00	(16.3)%	USD	(0.24)	0.24	2.93	(711.8)	705.7	57.4
TKO (TKO)	O	USD	189.30	240.00	(21.7)%	USD	2.26	5.25	5.72	83.8	36.0	33.1
FWONK (Liberty Media)	O	USD	94.17	120.00	(23.4)%	USD	2.19	2.01	2.46	42.9	46.7	38.2
SPOT (Spotify)	O	USD	528.84	625.00	(40.9)%	EUR	10.51	12.42	15.82	43.9	37.1	29.1
WMG (Warner Music)	O	USD	27.95	39.00	(31.6)%	USD	1.42	1.74	1.96	19.7	16.0	14.2
DKNG (DraftKings)	O	USD	22.47	29.00	(63.0)%	USD	0.61	0.90	1.68	37.1	24.9	13.4
FLUT (Flutter)	M	USD	92.50	110.00	(82.6)%	USD	7.91	4.68	5.55	11.7	19.8	16.7
SPX			7,637.76									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

WMG, DKNG, FLUT estimate is Adjusted EPS; WMG, DKNG, FLUT valuation is Adjusted P/E (x);

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.



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